

Prof. Dr. Jane K. Lê | Chair of Strategic Management

AI in research (methods)

An innovation too far?



A bit of storytelling & appreciation

The road to Pisa.

feat. Filippo Chiarello & Vito Giordano



I said no

RE: Invitation to deliver a keynote at the Pisa Summer School on Text Analysis...



Le, Jane

To Filippo Chiarello

Cc Vito Giordano



11.11.2025

Dear Filippo and Vito,

Thank you very much for this kind invitation. This sounds like a really interesting event. Certainly, there are lots of discussions about the use of AI in the research methods space and I think these discussions will be very important for the future of the field.

As an interpretivist, however, I am quite critical of the role of AI in research methods. In particular, I think that AI violates a number of key assumptions that make it ill-suited to **interpretivist research**. I am thus not well suited to speak at an 'AI-positive' conference. I would take the mood in the room down a notch ;) There are, of course, as you would expect, split opinions on AI in research methods and the management sciences more broadly. Matthew Grimes at Cambridge, for instance, is quite AI positive and may make a good substitute speaker: <https://www.jbs.cam.ac.uk/people/matthew-grimes/>.

I wish you the best of luck with your conference on this very interesting topic.

Kind regards,

Jane

Prof. Dr. Jane Lê (she/her) | Chair of Strategic Management
WHU - OTTO BEISHEIM SCHOOL OF MANAGEMENT
Burgplatz 2, 56179 Vallendar, Germany
T +49 261 6509 725 | Fax: +49 261 6509 509
E jane.le@whu.edu | W <http://whu.edu>

They said

“Our intention is... (to) encourage a serious, balanced discussion of these tools”.

“A stronger and more informed debate on these methods is essential for young scholar in innovation and management, and your viewpoint would add real depth to the conversation”.

devil's advocate



Debate as the gateway to healthy science

Ali Shilatifard (2002) in Science Advances

“Constructive criticism and debates are at the heart of scientific discovery and should continue as the framework for scientific progress. Scientists do not have all the answers”.

Debate as the gateway to healthy science

Gergen & Gergen (2003: 585)

“One might view such critiques as numbing in consequence, possibly functioning as an enervating backlash, a return to the conventional, and the end to methodological experiments. It could also fragment the field, as researchers may simply terminate dialogue and go their separate ways. However, such outcomes would be both unfortunate and unwarranted.”

Introduction



Expert in Qualitative Research Methods



Qualitative Researcher

Empirical

- Competing strategic goals
- Complex ‘grand’ challenges
- Strategy-as-practice
- Paradox
- Change and emotions

“how people in organizations experience and respond to strategic complexity”

Methodological

- Ethnographic writing
- Process research
- Innovation
- Technology

“quality in qualitative methods”

Illustrative Empirical Project



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Toward a Theory of Coordinating Mechanisms in Practice

Paula A. Jarzabkowski, Jane K. Lê, Martha S. Feldman

Published Online: 19 Oct 2011 | <https://doi.org/10.1287/orsc.1110.>

Abstract

This paper uses a practice perspective to study coordinating mechanisms that are continuously created and modified in order to enact organizational change based on the case of Servico, an organization undergoing a major response to a change in government regulation. In our case, the concept of a coordinating mechanism referred to as end-to-end practice. They do this via five performative-ostensive cycles:

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[Academy of Management Journal](#), Vol. 62, No. 3 | [Articles](#)

The Social Practice of Coevolving Strategy and Structure to Realize Mandated Radical Change

Paula Jarzabkowski, Jane Lê and Julia Balogun

Published Online: 14 Jun 2019 | <https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2016.0689>

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Abstract

This paper draws on a longitudinal interpretive case study to develop a theoretical model of actions by people across an organization coevolve strategy and structure in order to realize radical change. Mandated change, imposed by a powerful external actor, extends un-



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Triggers, Traps, and Disconnect: How Governance Obstacles Hinder Progress on Grand Challenges

Fannie Couture, Paula Jarzabkowski and Jane K. Lê

Published Online: 19 Dec 2023 | <https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2020.1716>

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Abstract

In this paper, we adopt a multistakeholder governance perspective to study how people collectively respond to a grand challenge. Specifically, we show how working through governance obstacles—that is, coordinating and collaborating challenges arising from a multistakeholder governance approach to responding to grand challenges—can erode actors' ability to mitigate these wicked problems. We

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Producing persuasive findings: Demystifying strategy and organization research
Paula Jarzabkowski, Rebecca Bednarek, Jane K Lê
First Published October 9, 2014 | Research Article | <https://doi.org/10.1177/1476127014554575>
Article information

Abstract
Despite the importance and proliferation of ethnographic research, the central issue of how to present ethnographic findings and narratives we craft to share our experience of the field and provide the primary basis for our theorizing. In this article, we are involved in writing persuasive findings. We provide an analysis as it is recorded within fieldnotes and explain the necessary must be done to render such data persuasive, drawing on

Organizational Research Methods

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The Practice of Innovating Research Methods
Jane Kirsten Lê, Torsten Schmid
First Published July 14, 2020 | Review Article | <https://doi.org/10.1177/1094428120935498>
Article information

Abstract
In this article, we examine how scholars in published qualitative strategy and management academic papers, that is, papers that demonstrate research process. We work through these papers highlighting concrete ways in which scholars research process: data generation, data analysis, we develop a two-layered “iceberg” important principles guide the innovative use are engaging in holistic innovation, being engaged in developing theory and method together, and demystifies the largely implicit process of innovation orient and encourage a more creative use of

The Journal of Applied Behavioral Science

NTL Institute Impact Factor: 2.7 / 5-Year Impact Factor: 4.5 Journal Home

Open access | Research article | First published online June 15, 2026

Advanced Qualitative Analyses for Theorizing: Balancing Deep Data Engagement With Imaginative Theorizing
Tine Köhler, Jane Lê, and Anne Smith [View all authors and affiliations](#)
OnlineFirst | <https://doi.org/10.1177/00218863261429182>

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Abstract
Qualitative research crucially contributes to knowledge generation via theory development, refinement, and refutation. A plethora of resources exist facilitating raw data engagement and immersion strategies. Yet, advanced analytic techniques for deriving theoretical insight are scanty understood and documented in the methods literature. The current paper creates a procedural framework for advancing theoretical insight via the use of qualitative analytic techniques by collating insights from the groundbreaking work of Klag and Langley, Langley, Locke et al., and Locke—which builds heavily on Peirce’s work on abduction and Weick’s work on disciplined imagination. We construct this framework around three core processes: challenging, seeing, and articulating. We provide three practical examples from our own research projects to demonstrate how these core processes are supported by advanced analytic techniques. We discuss the impact of different theorizing goals, different epistemological grounding, future applications, and further methodological development.

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Feature Topic for ORM: Advanced Analytic Approaches to Theorize From Qualitative Research

[Tine Köhler](#), [Anne Smith](#), [Thomas Greckhamer](#), and [Jane Lê](#) [View all authors and affiliations](#)

[Volume 28, Issue 2](#) | <https://doi.org/10.1177/10944281251314059> | [View article versions](#)

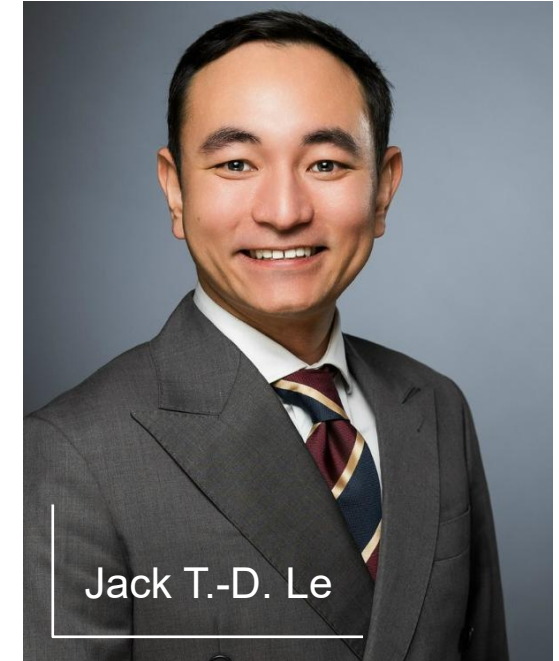
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Background and Purpose

A core goal, if not the core goal, of qualitative research is theory development and refinement ([Bansal et al., 2018](#); [Gephart, 2004](#); [Pratt, 2008](#); [Pratt & Bonaccio, 2016](#)). Yet, processes of theorizing from qualitative research are rarely explicitly described in journal publications and thus frequently remain shrouded in mystery ([Klag & Langley, 2013](#); [Locke et al., 2008](#)). There is no shortage of instructional materials (e.g., textbooks, book chapters, journal articles, online tutorials) that describe analytic techniques related to getting to know and managing one's raw data and summarizing its core content (i.e., texts on coding, extraction of themes, case summaries, content categorization). However, methodological treatments of more advanced analytic processes that focus on building insights from those initial raw data analyses in order to generate theory are largely lacking ([Klag & Langley, 2013](#); [Locke et al., 2022](#)).

Groundbreaking articles—such as the ones by [Weick \(1989\)](#) on disciplined imagination, by [Klag and Langley \(2013\)](#) on conceptual learning, and by [Locke et al. \(2008\)](#) on the generative role of doubt—have provided the

Recent Project: AI in Qualitative Research



Why this matters?

Lisa Lambert (August, 2026)

“Methods are the foundation of good science.”

Why this matters right now?

Bill Gates (August 2026)

“The choices we make now are critical.”

Why this matters right now?

- Nguyen, D. C., & Welch, C. (2026). Generative Artificial Intelligence in Qualitative Data Analysis: Analyzing—Or **Just Chatting**? *Organizational Research Methods*, 29(1), 3-39.
- Levitt, H. M. (2026). A consideration of the **ethics and methodological integrity** of generative artificial intelligence in qualitative research: Guidelines for Qualitative Psychology [Editorial]. *Qualitative Psychology*, 13(1), 1–5.
- Cornelissen, J. P. (2026). **The Artificial Intelligence Con**: The commodification of theory and the new and improved credibility crisis. *Organization Studies*, 0(0).
- Lindebaum, D. and Fleming, P. (2024), ChatGPT **Undermines Human Reflexivity**, Scientific Responsibility and Responsible Management Research. *British Journal of Management*, 35: 566-575.
- Davison, R.M., Díaz Andrade, A., Eckhardt, A., van Offenbeek, M., Techatassanasoontorn, A.A., Marabelli, M., Nielsen, P., Panteli, N., Schwabe, G., Hardin, A. and Cooper, V. (2026), Research **Integrity** Matters, But It **Is Undermined** by Generative AI. *Information Systems Journal*.

The figure displays three screenshots of the article's web interface. The top screenshot shows the desktop view with the article title, authors, and abstract. The middle screenshot shows the tablet view with a similar layout but adjusted for a smaller screen. The bottom screenshot shows the mobile view with a more compact layout, focusing on the article title and abstract. All three views include navigation options like 'Open access', 'Research article', and 'First published online'.

Why this matters right now?

95%

of UK Undergrads

use AI for their studies, often
specifically to help with assessed
work

01

Provocation



Do we want ‘fast science’?

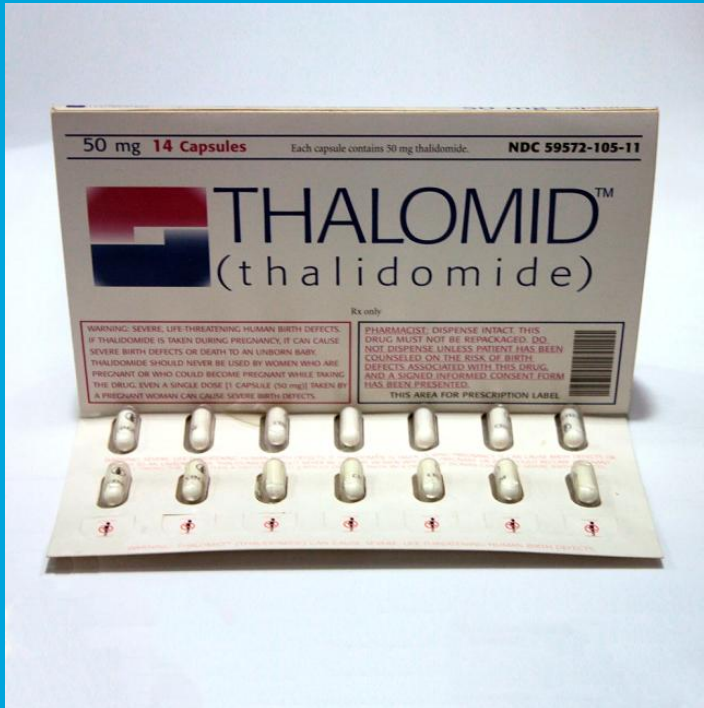
Fast Fashion. Fast Food. Fast Science.

Isabelle Stengers

Slow, careful science is under threat. Thoughtful consideration and deliberate questioning are at risk. Plurality disappears. New fields don't develop.



Fast Science (and Policy) can be Risky



Fast Science (and Policy) can be Risky

Bill Gates (August 2026)

“I believe we need time to prepare for the period of social, political, and economic upheaval we are about to enter. If someone had a credible plan for slowing down AI advances globally, I would like support it...”

And

What is the Role of Science in Society?

Gergen (1978)

“...to challenge prevailing assumptions regarding social life and to offer fresh alternatives to contemporary patterns of conduct”.

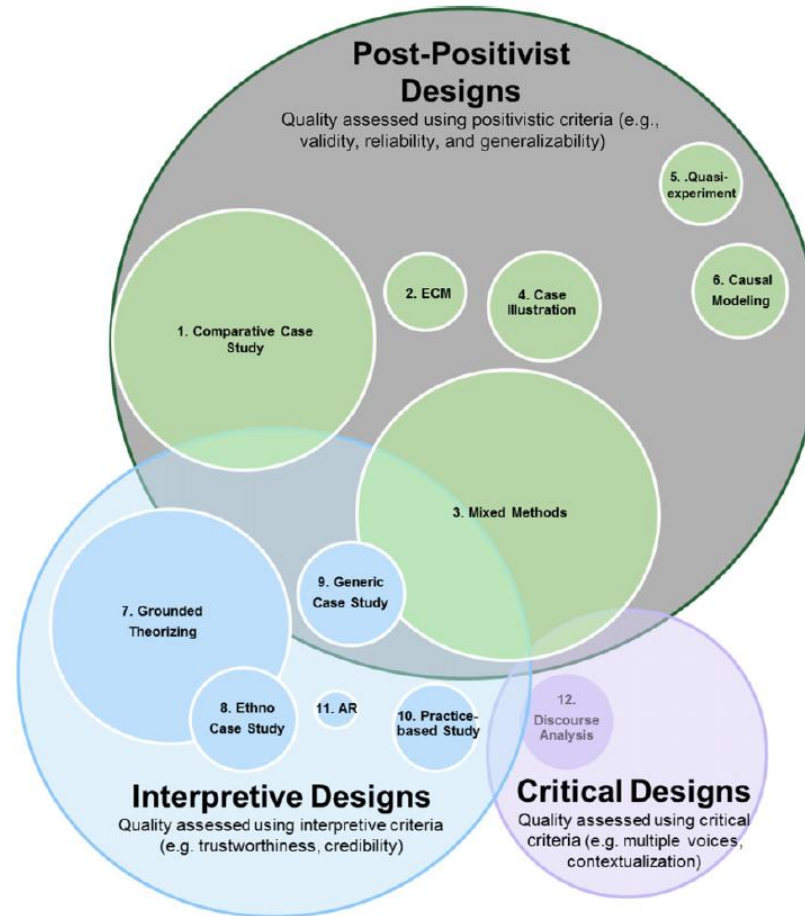
02

Provocation



**Is this even
qualitative?**

Qualitative Designs-in-Use



- | | |
|---------------------------|----------------------------|
| 7. Comparative Case Study | 1. Grounded Theory |
| 8. Extended Case Method | 2. Ethnographic Case Study |
| 9. Mixed Methods | 3. Generic Case Study |
| 10. Case Illustration | 4. Practice-Based Research |
| 11. Quasi-Experiment | 5. Action Research |
| 12. Causal Modelling | 6. Discourse Analysis |

What is Qualitative Research?

Denzin & Lincoln (2005: 3)

Qualitative research **is a situated activity** that locates the observer in the world. It consists of a set of **interpretive, material practices** that make the world visible. These practices transform the world. They turn the world into a series of representations, including field notes, interviews, conversations, photographs, recordings, and memos to the self. At this level, qualitative research involves an **interpretive, naturalistic approach** to the world. This means that qualitative researchers study things in their natural settings, attempting to make sense of, or **interpret, phenomena in terms of the meanings people bring to them.**

What is Qualitative Research?

Characteristics

- **Social construction** — construction of meaning within socially situated practices
- **Skilled** — studied, enacted, practice
- **Pluralistic** — privileges no single methodological practice over another
- **Nuanced** — rich and fine grounded naturalistic accounts
- **Complex** — embraces tensions, contrasts, negative cases
- **Social** — human-to-human relationship constructs 'social' reality
- **Reflexive** — reflexivity, multiple voicing, representation, presentation
- **Iterative** — attention to the process of doing qualitative research

Are you really doing qualitative research?

Qualitative data vs. qualitative analysis

Kenneth Gergen (1978: 1344) riled against traditional positivist empiricist assumptions arguing they produced highly restrictive designs and curtailed the field.

Flick (2002: 3): "Rapid social change and the resulting diversification of life worlds are increasingly confronting social researchers with new social contexts and perspectives...traditional deductive methodologies... are failing...thus research is increasingly forced to make use of inductive strategies...knowledge and practice are studied as local knowledge and practice" (p. 2).

03

Provocation



Can AI really do that?

AI as the Magic Bullet

- Solves our methods problems (e.g., removes research bias; supplements expertise)
 - Increases speed and allows multiplies outputs
 - Absolves us from data work (e.g., coding/analysis)
 - Theorizes for us
 - Writes manuscripts for us
- **A promise made** (faster, better science) **is often not a promise kept** (sloppy ‘good enough’ science)

But is that Happening?

“Scientific fraudsters massively outproduce careful researchers”



<https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/impactofsocialsciences/2026/03/17/research-integrity-is-locked-into-an-arms-race-with-agentic-ai-slop/>

GenAI is not a Method

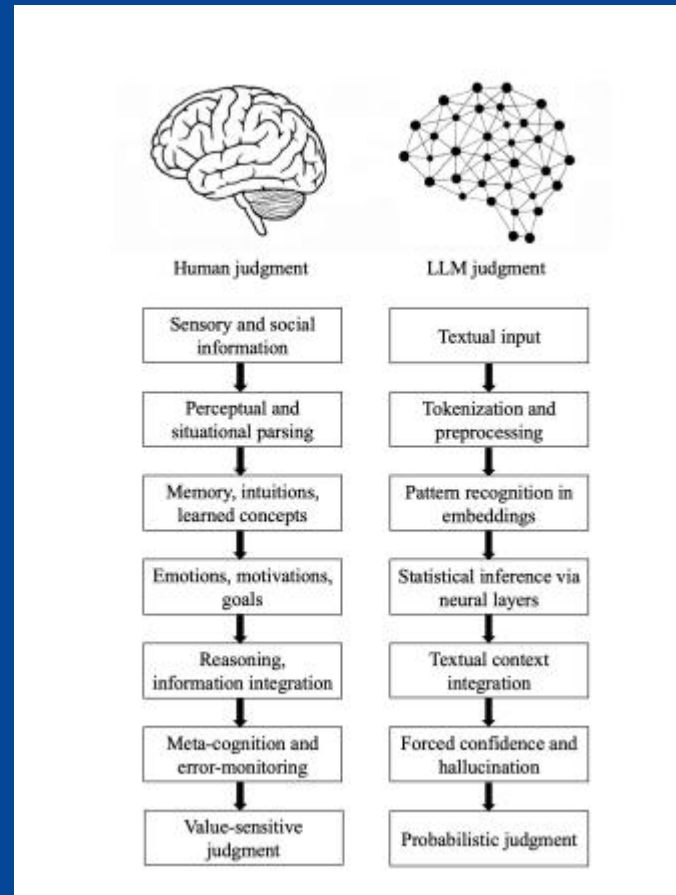
Definition

To be a method, there needs to be a systematic, repeatable approach that can be applied across different research projects with predictable types of outcomes that are driven by the specific steps taken in the analysis process. The analytic process needs to be known and malleable by the researcher.

- Problem 1: Writing prompts is not an analytic process
- Problem 2: Most people do not know how the genAI operates
- Problem 3: Many people do not understand the principles they want to apply

Probabilistic Judgement is not Interpretation

Quattrocioni, Capraro & Perc (2025)



And it Gets Worse

Violating Key Assumptions of Qualitative Research

- Qualitative research is not just text analysis!
 - genAI or LLM based research does not analyze text; it produces a **quantitative** probabilistic calculation of a word string that looks similar to the training data provided
- Practically no engagement with qualitative method (e.g., grounded theory, discourse analysis).
 - How would a particular qualitative method be suitably carried out with genAI following the prescribed analytic processes of that method?
- No consideration of ontological and epistemological groundings at all!
- No engagement with researcher positionality while interacting with the data, participants, or context.

And Worse

Some Problems

- Many of the genAI methods pieces (even if they come from big name researchers and are published in reputable journals) are **OPINION PIECES not TRUE METHODS**
- Many researchers in this space have a commercial interest in genAI (that includes other academics and researchers)
- Many of the outputs genAI creates look like analytical outputs; that doesn't mean it actually ran any analysis or that it even can

What would ChatGPT say?

I definitely absolutely can and would you like to try?

- I'm not designed to have human-style independent judgment or firsthand understanding.
- I don't have lived experience, embodied understanding, or a researcher's situated relationship with participants and context.
- I can independently produce an interpretation of qualitative data, but whether that constitutes the kind of interpretation your methodology considers valid is an epistemological and methodological question.
- The more difficult question—and I suspect this is what you're ultimately getting at—is whether an LLM can generate genuinely emergent concepts, rather than merely recombining conceptual patterns it has already learned from human language. That's a much harder question, and I wouldn't want to answer it with an unqualified yes.

What would Gemini say?

I definitely absolutely can and would you like to try?

- No AI cannot *genuinely* conduct interpretivist analysis in the epistemological sense.
- Interpretivism rests on the premise that knowledge is socially constructed through lived human experience, empathy, and shared cultural context. Because I lack subjective consciousness, lived experience, and genuine empathy, I cannot authentically "interpret" meaning. What I do instead is **advanced semantic pattern recognition**.
- Machine Pattern Matching Simulates "Coding"
- In qualitative methodology, coding is not mere data processing—it is an interpretative act where the researcher is the primary analytical instrument. Because I lack reflexivity and lived human experience, any "coding" I generate autonomously is just statistical grouping, not genuine qualitative analysis.

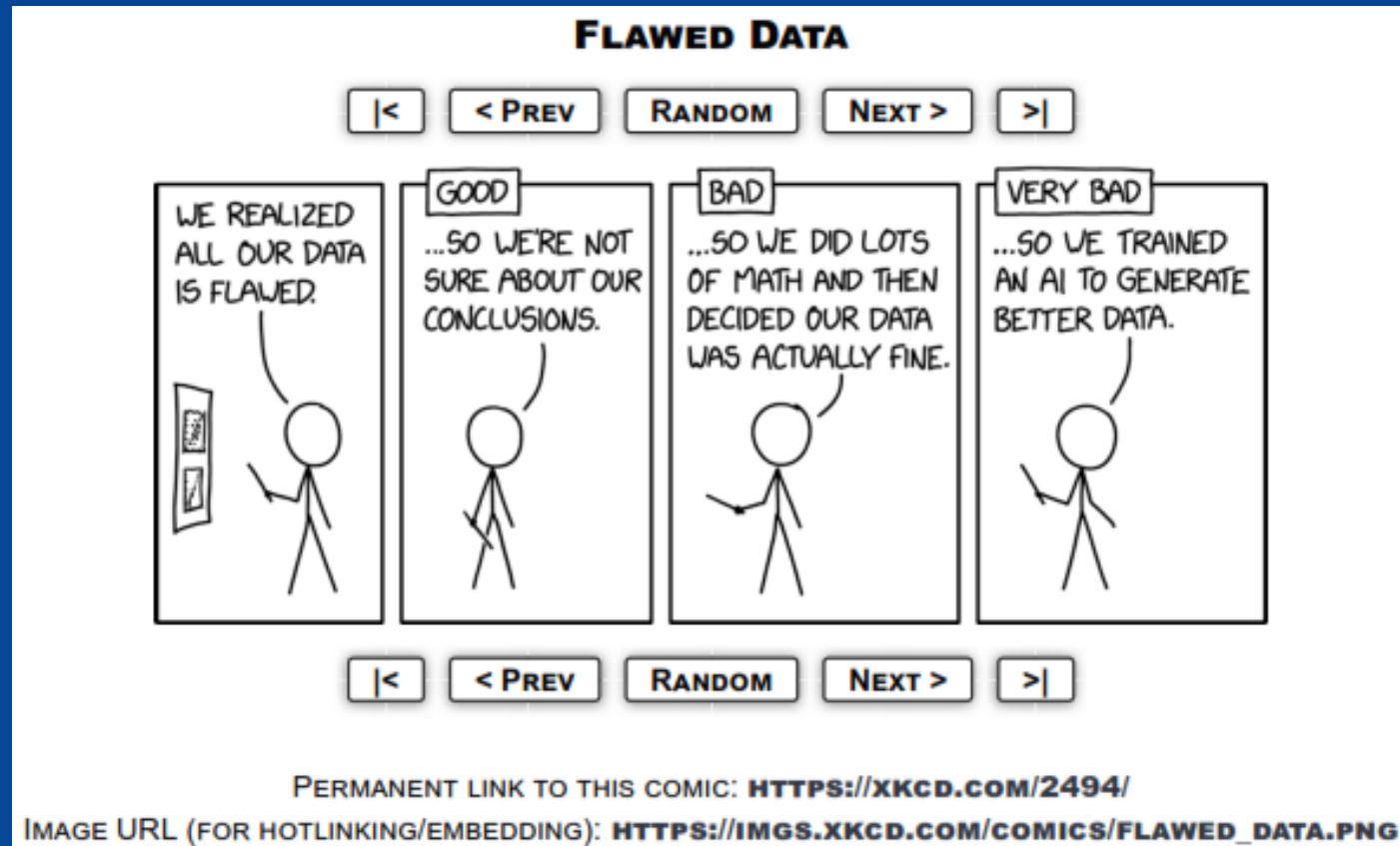
What would Claude say?

I definitely absolutely can and would you like to try?

- Interpretivism is about situated, subjective meaning-making — I don't have lived experience, so my "interpretations" are pattern-based inferences, not embodied understanding.
- There's a distinction between: (1) **Doing interpretivist analysis** — which requires a knowing subject who brings situated understanding, has a stake in the meaning-making, and can be reflexively aware of how their own position shapes what they see. Interpretation isn't just pattern extraction — it's meaning construction by someone. (2) **Producing outputs that look like the products of interpretivist analysis** — coded transcripts, theme clusters, memos that sound plausible. **I can do (2).**
- Whether that constitutes "interpretation" in the phenomenological sense interpretivism – The honest answer is probably no, not in the way Geertz or Denzin meant it.
- I shouldn't be described as doing the interpretivist work.

And

Synthetic... Everything?



04

Provocation



Is AI even a meaningful innovation?

Principles of Research Methods Innovation

Le & Schmid (2022)

- **Holistic innovation:** All aspects of a method are interdependent; true innovation involves crafting and implementing innovation in multiple parts of the research design
- **Transparency:** No credibility without excruciating clarity of description and audit trails; educate your audience
- **Method-theory entanglement:** Develop method and theory together; a methodological innovation should lead to new theorizing
- **Reflexivity:** Stay true to onto-epistemological assumptions of the research tradition a particular method is embedded in.

Principles of Research Methods Innovation

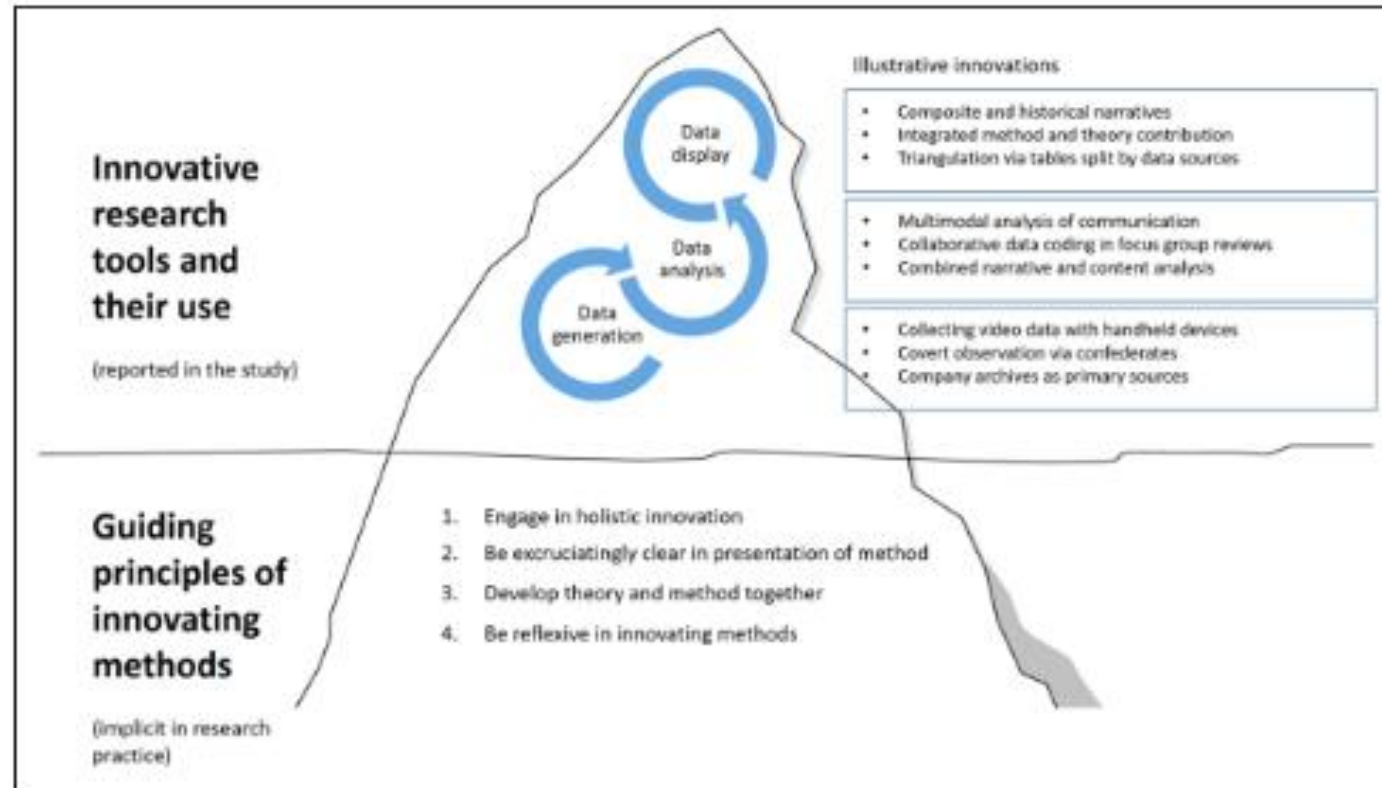


Figure 1. Innovating research methods as two-layered process ("innovation iceberg").

And

Back to Templates?

Le & Schmid (2022: 331)

“We should place the teaching of **proven methods alongside the development of practical skill**....This is critical to ensuring that methods retain the fluidity and flexibility with which they were created (e.g., Gioia, 2019), rather than simply becoming tools that **reproduce knowledge**. Hence, rather than teaching well-established research approaches as fixed templates, method trainings might use these as initial frameworks to orient and support students in order to later make creative use of established approaches for their own study.

Principles of Research Methods Innovation

Le & Schmid (2022)

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Reigniting Old Debates

Recurrent Themes in Qualitative Research

- **Quality criteria**
- **Standardization / templating**
- **Legitimization**
- **Technology and tools**
- **Bias**
- **Natural science courting (positivism/reductionism)**

05

Provocation



Are we driving AI or is AI driving us?

The Danger of Epistemic Capture

Morley (2026); Ros & Wevers (2025); Zubcic (2023); Zubcic & Giacomini (2024)

- Epistemic capture is a phenomenon whereby domain-specific expertise generates constrained epistemological frameworks that come to dominate analytical and decision-making processes
- This epistemic dominance occurs when specialized knowledge frameworks acquire privileged status as authoritative truth claims, transcending their original contextual boundaries (Haas 1992)
- Cognitive filter and as an institutional mechanism, constraining the scope of what is considered to be realistic or evidence-based
- Shape research outcomes, the underlying research frameworks and research discourse itself (self-reinforcing feedback loops)

Technological Watershed Moment Needs Debate

Punctuated equilibrium

- “...these turbulent interchanges have produced profound challenges to the ways in which the social sciences are understood and practiced” (Gergen & Gergen, 2003: 575)

Concluding Thoughts



And

What Does that Mean?

Antonio Guterres (UN Secretary-General, July 2026)

“Some decisions must
remain forever human.”

Let's debate!



WHU – Otto Beisheim School of Management

Contact person

Title / Department

WHU – Otto Beisheim School of Management

Campus Vallendar, Burgplatz 2, 56179 Vallendar, Germany

Campus Düsseldorf, Erkrather Str. 224a, 40233 Düsseldorf, Germany

Tel.: +49 (0)261-6509-Ext

Fax: +49 (0)261-6509-Ext

firstname.lastname@whu.edu

www.whu.edu

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